Australia’s satellite EO data continuity: 39 risks revisited

Independent comparison by George Dyke | 5 November 2026

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Reading this matrix. The 2024 ratings and direction indicators are taken from the original CEODA assessment as recorded in the working matrix. The 2026 movement and estimated status are a provisional, evidence-led interpretation of changes since 2024, not the result of a new formal or endorsed risk assessment.

At a glance: 15 risks show increased pressure (↑), 18 broadly unchanged pressure (→), and six reduced pressure (↓). Only PR4 is provisionally assessed as crossing a rating boundary, from MEDIUM to HIGH. The arrows describe pressure since 2024, not the direction originally projected in 2024.

Policy risks · 11

Risk ID	Risk statement	2024 rating	2024 outlook	2026 movement	2026 est. rating
PO1	Foreign government open/free data or distribution policy change	**VERY HIGH**	→	→	**VERY HIGH**
PO2	Foreign government acquisition strategy change	**VERY HIGH**	↑	↑	**VERY HIGH**
PO3	Foreign government exercises shutter or export controls for strategic or tactical reasons	**HIGH**	↓	↑	**HIGH**
PO4	Change in foreign partner government policy ambition/ability to provide world-leading satellite EO systems for operational or scientific needs	**VERY HIGH**	→	↑	**VERY HIGH**
PO5	Poor Australian burden-sharing leads to data providers not willing to provide free data to Australia	**HIGH**	↑	↓	**HIGH**
PO6	Lack of binding data supply agreements with key providers leads to sudden demise of supply	**VERY HIGH**	→	→	**VERY HIGH**
PO7	Change to WMO data policy or country participation	**HIGH**	→	↓	**HIGH**
PO8	Australia or strategic partners’ access to satellite launchers is restricted for strategic, geopolitical, or tactical reasons	**MEDIUM**	↑	→	**MEDIUM**
PO9	Changes in foreign policy or data availability arising from the increase in regional/international geopolitical conflict and tension	**VERY HIGH**	↑	↑	**VERY HIGH**
PO10	Australian Government policy restricts use of EO data sources from foreign governments and companies	**MEDIUM**	↑	→	**MEDIUM**
PO11	Australia prioritises foreign partnerships in EO based on national security or defence needs, instead of civilian needs	**MEDIUM**	↑	↑	**MEDIUM**

Market risks · 6

Risk ID	Risk statement	2024 rating	2024 outlook	2026 movement	2026 est. rating
M1	Potential disruptions or fluctuations in the availability or cost of a product due to changes in overall market conditions or market failures	**MEDIUM**	→	→	**MEDIUM**
M2	Commercial market demand for on demand acquisition services saturates capacity	**MEDIUM**	↑	↑	**MEDIUM**
M3	Changes to international free and open data policy reduce or impede commercial viability of EO products and services	**MEDIUM**	→	→	**MEDIUM**
M4	Significant downturn in the Australian economy means foreign commercial data becomes too expensive for users	**MEDIUM**	→	→	**MEDIUM**
M5	Globalisation means domestic Australian EO data service providers become too expensive	**HIGH**	→	→	**HIGH**
M6	Obsolete or discontinued software and/or platforms	**MEDIUM**	→	→	**MEDIUM**

Programmatic risks · 11

Risk ID	Risk statement	2024 rating	2024 outlook	2026 movement	2026 est. rating
PR1	Reliance on international partners to select, develop, fund, and operate missions that correspond to Australian needs	**MEDIUM**	→	↓	**MEDIUM**
PR2	Loss of key missions due to launch failure	**LOW**	→	→	**LOW**
PR3	Loss of access to or significant delays in access to launch	**MEDIUM**	→	↑	**MEDIUM**
PR4	Foreign government priorities change, shifting space agency programs	**MEDIUM**	→	↑	**HIGH**
PR5	Sustaining Australian university capacity and support	**MEDIUM**	→	↑	**MEDIUM**
PR6	Australian Government program funding changes impact future key programs and infrastructure	**HIGH**	→	↓	**HIGH**
PR7	Australia's talent pool is insufficient to meet national needs	**MEDIUM**	→	↑	**MEDIUM**
PR8	Inability or delayed ability to respond to future data supply risks	**VERY HIGH**	→	→	**VERY HIGH**
PR9	Foreign government EO program designed to shift global power allegiances	**HIGH**	→	→	**HIGH**
PR10	Key EO missions reach end of life and are not replaced with new operational missions	**HIGH**	→	→	**HIGH**
PR11	Operational use of and dependence on research missions	**MINOR**	→	→	**MINOR**

Environmental risks · 5

Risk ID	Risk statement	2024 rating	2024 outlook	2026 movement	2026 est. rating
E1	Space debris collision destroys satellite	**MINOR**	↑	↑	**MINOR**
E2	Collision or series of collisions of other spacecraft degrade orbital environment or render it unusable and impact satellite performance and reliability	**MEDIUM**	↑	↑	**MEDIUM**
E3	Solar flare impacts spacecraft performance, lifetime or context	**MEDIUM**	→	↑	**MEDIUM**
E4	Communications uplink/downlink disrupted	**MINOR**	→	→	**MINOR**
E5	Terrestrial frequency interference	**MINOR**	→	↑	**MINOR**

Technical risks · 6

Risk ID	Risk statement	2024 rating	2024 outlook	2026 movement	2026 est. rating
T1	Failure or degradation of onboard systems leads to degraded or lost capability	**MINOR**	→	→	**MINOR**
T2	Ground segment systems failure	**MINOR**	→	→	**MINOR**
T3	Inability to independently verify satellite EO data provenance including data spoofing and tampering	**HIGH**	↑	↑	**HIGH**
T4	Inadequate training data to drive future AI uptake in Australia and/or other collaborating countries	**MEDIUM**	↑	↓	**MEDIUM**
T5	Insufficient or inconsistent calibration data or approaches	**MEDIUM**	↑	→	**MEDIUM**
T6	Inconsistent processing of Analysis Ready and derived data products	**MINOR**	→	↓	**MINOR**

Source: CEODA 2024→2026 Risk Workspace, “Matrix - 39 Risks” (working copy). The underlying workbook is not published. Original CEODA assessment: https://www.eoa.org.au/s/Continuity-of-Earth-Observation-Data-for-Australia-Risks.pdf
Outside this 39-risk comparison: deliberate counterspace operations against EO systems and restriction of access to foreign-controlled frontier AI are considered separately as emerging issues; neither has been retrospectively scored in this matrix.